

the masses and how to “engineer consent” for political gain. Bernays got his passion for psychology from his uncle Sigmund Freud. Yeah, that Freud.

Bernays made a career of intentionally tapping in to people’s irrationality and unconscious impulses to sell products. He believed that our unconscious “animal instincts” could be used to sell middle-class consumers products they didn’t strictly need, a practice that was previously reserved for the uber wealthy. He marketed products not to meet a need, but to reflect the buyer’s personal identity. Sound familiar?

It’s not like the desire for things is new, but before mass production, you had to wait for them. Things were made by hand, they took time, and cost a higher percentage of your household income. By the end of the Industrial Revolution in 1840, goods were much easier to manufacture. But in order for these large-scale productions to keep up with costs, the market had to inform people that they no longer had to wait or pay as much to get what they want when they want it. My favorite quote from *Propaganda* sums up Bernays’s marketing framework for profitable mass production:

“Mass production is profitable only if its rhythm can be maintained—that is, if it can continue to sell its product in steady or increasing quantity. . . . Today supply must actively seek to create its corresponding demand . . . [and] cannot afford to wait until the public asks for its product; it must maintain constant touch, through advertising and propaganda . . . to assure itself the continuous demand which alone will make its costly plant profitable.”

Companies are not just in the business of manufacturing products; they’re also in the business of manufacturing desire.

Constantly Moving Happiness Machines

Bernays was also instrumental in creating the idea that recreational shopping is a civic duty. President Herbert Hoover was one of several politicians who sought out Bernays to help sell his policy ideas and campaigns. Hoover once told a group of advertising executives: “You have taken over the job of creating desire and have transformed people into constantly moving happiness machines, machines which have become the key to economic progress.”